pause to reflect on where we are and how we got here. Geelani has reminded us that his fate is not special, that there are many in his generation, in Kashmir and elsewhere, who have had to go through things that are as bad, or worse. And few have had his good fortune, to come out of it alive and sane. For their sake, and so that Geelani's quiet and dignified fight for justice for those still in prison, or are facing the gallows, or have 'disappeared', or have turned up with bullets in their heads, we must all continue to ask some very hard questions, for a very long time. It is possible that the mainstream media will be a weapon in the process of silencing such questions. It is also possible that professionals in the mainstream media will become more aware and sensitive to the ethical and professional demands associated with their practice, and will occasionally refuse to toe the lines dictated in smoke-filled backrooms where channel executives, editors, senior correspondents and intelligence agents gather for quiet chats. We hope for the latter, the demands of justice, and freedom in South Asia, will depend on such acts of refusal to 'spin' stories out of blood and smoke.

This essay has been adapted from a posting made on the Sarai Reader List on 5 August 2005.